

Meridian Technologies Group

Employee Policy Handbook

Consolidated People, Security and Finance Policies
Version 4.2 — Effective 01 April 2026

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Applies To	All permanent, fixed-term and probationary employees of Meridian Technologies Group and its subsidiaries

This handbook supersedes all previously issued policy circulars, memoranda and departmental practice notes on the subjects covered herein. Where a conflict exists between this handbook and an individual employment contract, the employment contract prevails only to the extent that it provides a benefit more favourable to the employee.

Document Control and Revision History

Version	Date	Author	Summary of Change
1.0	12 Jan 2019	HR Operations	Initial consolidated handbook issued.
2.0	03 Feb 2021	HR Operations	Added Remote and Hybrid Work Policy (Section 3) following pandemic pilot.
3.0	15 Jun 2023	HR Policy Office	Revised expense limits; introduced grade-based annual leave matrix.
3.1	20 Nov 2023	Information Security	Updated Section 5 for mandatory multi-factor authentication.
4.0	07 Jan 2025	HR Policy Office	Added Section 8 (Learning and Development) and Section 9 (Grievance).
4.1	12 Sep 2025	Finance Shared Services	Per diem rates increased; mileage rate revised to 0.62 per kilometre.
4.2	18 Mar 2026	HR Policy Office	Added generative AI usage clauses (5.7); parental leave extended to 16 weeks.

Definitions

Term	Definition
Company	Meridian Technologies Group and any entity in which it holds a controlling interest.
Employee	Any individual engaged under a contract of employment with the Company, including probationary and fixed-term sta
Line Manager	The individual to whom an employee directly reports in the approved organisation structure.
Grade	The job level assigned to a position under the Company's grading framework, from G1 (entry) to G9 (executive).
Working Day	Sunday to Thursday, excluding public holidays declared by the Company.
Confidential Information	Any non-public information relating to the Company, its clients, employees or suppliers, in any format.
Company Device	Any laptop, mobile device, removable media or peripheral owned or leased by the Company.

Scope and General Principles

- 1.1 This handbook applies to all employees regardless of location, grade or contract type. Where local statutory law imposes a more generous entitlement than this handbook, the statutory entitlement applies and this handbook is read down accordingly.
- 1.2 Every employee is required to read this handbook within fifteen (15) working days of joining and to acknowledge receipt through the HR self-service portal. Failure to acknowledge does not exempt an employee from compliance.
- 1.3 Policies in this handbook may be amended by the Executive Management Committee. Material amendments will be communicated at least thirty (30) calendar days before taking effect, except where a shorter period is required by law or by an urgent security consideration.
- 1.4 Breach of any policy in this handbook may result in disciplinary action under Section 10, up to and including termination of employment and, where applicable, referral to law enforcement.

Section 2 — Leave and Time Off Policy

Policy ID: MTG-HR-002 | Owner: Head of HR Operations | Last reviewed: 18 March 2026

2.1 Annual Leave Entitlement

Annual leave accrues monthly from the first day of employment and is calculated on working days, not calendar days. Entitlement is determined by grade and by completed years of continuous service:

Grade Band	0-2 Years Service	3-5 Years Service	6+ Years Service
G1 - G3 (Associate)	20 working days	22 working days	24 working days
G4 - G5 (Professional)	22 working days	25 working days	27 working days
G6 - G7 (Manager)	25 working days	27 working days	30 working days
G8 - G9 (Executive)	30 working days	30 working days	30 working days

2.1.1 Employees may carry forward a maximum of ten (10) unused annual leave days into the following calendar year. Carried-forward days must be consumed by 31 March, after which they lapse without compensation.

2.1.2 Requests for annual leave of five (5) consecutive working days or more must be submitted at least twenty-one (21) calendar days in advance. Shorter absences require seven (7) calendar days' notice. The Company may decline a request on operational grounds, but will not decline more than two consecutive requests from the same employee in a calendar year.

2.1.3 On termination of employment, accrued but untaken annual leave is paid at the employee's basic salary rate. Leave taken in excess of accrual is recovered from the final settlement.

2.2 Sick Leave

Employees are entitled to paid sick leave as set out below in any rolling twelve (12) month period:

Period	Payment Rate	Documentation Required
Days 1 - 3	100% of full salary	Self-certification via HR portal
Days 4 - 15	100% of full salary	Medical certificate from a licensed practitioner
Days 16 - 45	50% of full salary	Medical certificate plus Company medical officer review
Days 46 - 90	Unpaid	Referral to Occupational Health and case conference

2.2.1 An employee unable to attend work due to illness must notify their line manager no later than 09:00 on the first day of absence, by telephone or instant message. Notification by email alone is not sufficient.

2.2.2 Sick leave may not be taken immediately before or immediately after annual leave without a medical certificate, regardless of duration.

2.3 Parental and Family Leave

- **Maternity leave:** sixteen (16) weeks at full pay, of which at least six (6) weeks must be taken immediately following delivery. Employees with less than one year of service receive twelve (12) weeks at full pay.
- **Paternity and partner leave:** ten (10) working days at full pay, to be taken within ninety (90) days of the birth or adoption placement.
- **Adoption leave:** mirrors maternity leave entitlement where the adopted child is under five (5) years of age.

- **Compassionate leave:** five (5) working days for the death of a spouse, child, parent or sibling; three (3) working days for a grandparent, parent-in-law or grandchild.
- **Marriage leave:** three (3) working days, available once per period of employment.

2.3.1 Returning parents are entitled to request a temporary reduction to 80% of contracted hours for up to six (6) months, with a proportionate salary adjustment. Such requests will not be unreasonably refused.

2.4 Unpaid and Special Leave

2.4.1 Unpaid leave of up to thirty (30) calendar days may be granted at the discretion of the Head of Department, subject to Group HR endorsement. Continuous service is preserved during approved unpaid leave, but annual leave and end-of-service benefits do not accrue.

2.4.2 Study leave of up to five (5) working days per calendar year is available for examinations relating to a qualification approved under Section 8 (Learning and Development).

Section 3 — Remote and Hybrid Work Policy

Policy ID: MTG-HR-003 | Owner: Head of Workplace Services | Last reviewed: 07 January 2025

3.1 Eligibility

3.1.1 Hybrid working is available to employees whose roles have been classified as **location-flexible** in the Role Classification Register maintained by HR. Roles classified as **site-dependent** (including data centre operations, facilities, reception and laboratory roles) are not eligible.

3.1.2 Employees must have completed their probationary period and hold a current performance rating of 'Meets Expectations' or above to participate in hybrid working.

3.2 Standard Hybrid Pattern

Arrangement	Minimum Days On-Site	Approval Level
Standard hybrid	3 days per week	Line manager
Extended remote	1 day per week	Head of Department
Fully remote (domestic)	4 days per quarter	Head of Department and Group HR
Cross-border remote	By exception only	Executive Management Committee

3.2.1 Tuesday and Wednesday are designated Company-wide anchor days. All employees working under a standard hybrid arrangement are expected on-site on both anchor days unless an exception is agreed in writing.

3.2.2 Cross-border remote work exceeding twenty (20) consecutive calendar days may create tax, immigration and permanent-establishment exposure for the Company. Such arrangements require prior written clearance from Group Tax and Group Legal, and will not be approved retrospectively.

3.3 Home Workspace Requirements

- A dedicated workspace with a door or partition that allows confidential calls to be taken without being overheard by household members or visitors.
- A broadband connection with a sustained downlink of at least 25 Mbps and uplink of at least 5 Mbps.
- Use of the Company-issued laptop only. Personal devices may not be used to access Company systems except through the approved virtual desktop published at vdi.meridian-tech.internal.
- A locking drawer or cabinet for any printed material classified Internal or above.

3.3.1 The Company provides a one-time home office allowance of 600 (six hundred) in local currency for eligible employees, claimable through the expense system under category HYB-SETUP. The allowance is claimable once every thirty-six (36) months and covers a chair, monitor, keyboard and desk lamp. It does not cover furniture in excess of these items, internet subscriptions or utility costs.

3.4 Availability and Core Hours

3.4.1 Core collaboration hours are 10:00 to 16:00 local time. Employees must be reachable via the Company messaging platform and able to join a video call within fifteen (15) minutes during core hours.

3.4.2 Calendars must accurately reflect the employee's working location for each day. Persistent failure to maintain an accurate calendar may result in withdrawal of hybrid eligibility.

3.4.3 Withdrawal of hybrid eligibility is not a disciplinary sanction and does not follow the process in Section 10, but the employee may raise a grievance under Section 9 if they believe the withdrawal was unreasonable.

Section 4 — Business Travel and Expense Reimbursement Policy

Policy ID: MTG-FIN-011 | Owner: Group Financial Controller | Last reviewed: 12 September 2025

4.1 General Principles

4.1.1 Employees must incur only expenses that are necessary, reasonable and directly related to Company business. Where a lower-cost option is reasonably available and does not materially affect the business outcome, the lower-cost option must be selected.

4.1.2 All travel must be booked through the Company's appointed travel management company. Bookings made outside this channel will be reimbursed only up to the fare that would have been available through the appointed agency at the time of booking.

4.2 Air Travel Class Entitlement

Flight Duration	G1 - G5	G6 - G7	G8 - G9
Under 4 hours	Economy	Economy	Business
4 to 7 hours	Economy	Premium Economy	Business
Over 7 hours	Premium Economy	Business	Business

4.2.1 Flight duration is measured as total scheduled flying time on the outbound journey, excluding layovers of less than three (3) hours.

4.2.2 Employees may not upgrade using Company funds. Personal loyalty points may be used for upgrades at no cost to the Company and remain the property of the employee.

4.3 Accommodation and Daily Allowance

Per diem covers meals, local incidentals and personal communication. It is paid for each full day of travel and at 50% for the day of departure and the day of return.

Destination Tier	Example Cities	Hotel Cap (per night)	Per Diem (per day)
Tier 1	London, New York, Zurich, Tokyo, Singapore	320	95
Tier 2	Dubai, Doha, Berlin, Toronto, Sydney	240	75
Tier 3	Cairo, Mumbai, Manila, Nairobi, Bogota	150	55
Domestic	All locations within country of employment	180	60

4.3.1 Caps are stated in USD equivalent and exclude local taxes and mandatory service charges. Where the cap is exceeded due to a Company-organised event at a designated venue, the excess is payable on production of the event confirmation.

4.3.2 Where meals are provided by a host, conference or airline, the per diem is reduced by 25% for breakfast, 35% for lunch and 40% for dinner.

4.4 Ground Transport and Mileage

- Mileage for use of a personal vehicle is reimbursed at **0.62 per kilometre**, inclusive of fuel, wear and insurance. Separate fuel receipts are not reimbursable when mileage is claimed.
- Taxi and ride-hailing services are reimbursable for journeys where public transport is impractical, unsafe or would take more than double the equivalent journey time.

- Car rental is limited to intermediate category or below unless three or more employees travel together.
- Traffic fines, parking penalties and toll evasion charges are never reimbursable and remain the personal liability of the employee.

4.5 Non-Reimbursable Expenses

The following are not reimbursable under any circumstances: alcoholic beverages (except at a client entertainment event pre-approved by a G7 or above); in-flight gambling or entertainment purchases; spa, gym and minibar charges; flight or hotel upgrades paid in cash; loss or damage to personal property; childcare and pet boarding; and expenses incurred by an accompanying spouse, partner or family member.

4.6 Submission and Approval

4.6.1 Claims must be submitted within **thirty (30) calendar days** of the expense being incurred. Claims submitted between 31 and 60 days require Head of Department approval with a written justification. Claims older than sixty (60) days will be rejected.

4.6.2 Itemised receipts are mandatory for every line item of 25 or more. Credit card statements are not accepted as receipts. Lost receipts require a signed missing-receipt declaration, limited to three (3) occurrences per employee per calendar year.

Claim Value (single report)	Required Approver
Up to 500	Line manager
501 to 2,500	Head of Department
2,501 to 10,000	Divisional Director
Above 10,000	Group Financial Controller and Divisional Director

4.6.3 Approved claims are settled in the payroll cycle following approval, provided approval is recorded before the 20th of the month. Reimbursement is made to the employee's registered salary account only.

Section 5 — Information Security and Acceptable Use Policy

Policy ID: MTG-SEC-001 | Owner: Chief Information Security Officer | Last reviewed: 18 March 2026

5.1 Data Classification

Classification	Description	Handling Requirement
Public	Approved for external release (marketing materials, published financials).	Not restricted
Internal	Default classification for Company information. Company systems only; do not post publicly.	Not restricted
Confidential	Client data, contracts, salary and personal data.	Encrypt in transit and at rest; share on a need-to-know basis; external share prohibited.
Restricted	Source code for core platform, M&A material, security keys, dual access for any app.	Share only on a need-to-know basis; access approved by the data owner; access review required.

5.2 Authentication and Access

- Passwords must be at least fourteen (14) characters and may not reuse any of the previous ten (10) passwords. Passwords do not expire on a fixed schedule but must be changed immediately on suspicion of compromise.
- Multi-factor authentication is mandatory for all systems accessed from outside the corporate network, without exception.
- Credentials must never be shared, including with IT support staff. No member of the IT Service Desk will ever request a password.
- Access rights are granted on the principle of least privilege and are recertified by line managers every ninety (90) days.
- Accounts are disabled within four (4) hours of a leaver's final working hour and deleted after ninety (90) days.

5.3 Device Security

5.3.1 Company devices must have full-disk encryption enabled, an automatic screen lock of no more than five (5) minutes, and the Company endpoint agent running and reporting. Employees may not disable, uninstall or interfere with security agents.

5.3.2 Software may be installed only from the Company Software Catalogue. Requests for software not in the catalogue must be raised through the Service Desk and are subject to security and licensing review, typically completed within ten (10) working days.

5.3.3 Loss or theft of a Company device must be reported to the Service Desk within **two (2) hours** of discovery, and to the local police within twenty-four (24) hours where the device contained Confidential or Restricted information.

5.4 Email, Messaging and Internet Use

5.4.1 Limited personal use of Company email and internet is permitted provided it is reasonable in volume, does not interfere with duties, does not incur cost to the Company and does not involve prohibited content.

5.4.2 Prohibited use includes accessing or distributing pornographic, discriminatory, violent or extremist material; operating a personal business; unauthorised cryptocurrency mining; circumventing web filtering through proxies or personal VPNs; and auto-forwarding Company mail to a personal address.

5.4.3 The Company monitors network traffic, email metadata and endpoint activity for security and compliance purposes, in accordance with applicable data protection law. Employees should have no expectation of privacy in respect of activity conducted on Company systems.

5.5 Incident Reporting

5.5.1 Any suspected security incident — including phishing, malware alerts, misdirected email containing personal data, or unauthorised physical access — must be reported immediately to soc@meridian-tech.example or via the 24-hour hotline extension 4040.

5.5.2 Employees who report an incident in good faith will not face disciplinary action for having caused it, provided the underlying act was not deliberate or grossly negligent. Concealment of an incident is treated as gross misconduct.

5.6 Removable Media and Data Transfer

USB mass storage is disabled by default on all endpoints. Where a business need exists, a Company-issued hardware-encrypted drive may be requested with Head of Department and CISO approval, valid for a maximum of ninety (90) days. Transfer of Confidential data to personal cloud storage, personal email or consumer file-sharing services is prohibited in all cases.

5.7 Use of Generative Artificial Intelligence Tools

5.7.1 Only AI tools listed in the Approved AI Tooling Register may be used for Company work. The register is maintained by the CISO and published on the intranet.

5.7.2 Confidential and Restricted information, personal data of employees or clients, and source code from the core platform repository must never be entered into a public or consumer-tier AI service. Enterprise-tier services with contractual no-training guarantees may be used for Confidential data where explicitly listed in the register.

5.7.3 Employees remain fully accountable for any output they submit, publish or commit. AI-generated code must pass the standard review process and may not be merged on the basis of AI review alone. AI-generated material used in client deliverables must be substantively reviewed and verified by a competent employee.

5.7.4 Use of AI tools to make or materially influence decisions about hiring, promotion, discipline or termination is prohibited without prior approval from Group HR and Group Legal.

Section 6 — Code of Conduct and Workplace Behaviour

Policy ID: MTG-HR-001 | Owner: Group Head of Human Resources | Last reviewed: 07 January 2025

6.1 Standards of Conduct

Employees are expected to act with integrity, treat colleagues, clients and suppliers with respect, comply with applicable laws, protect Company assets, and avoid any conduct that could reasonably damage the Company's reputation, whether inside or outside working hours.

6.2 Anti-Harassment and Anti-Discrimination

6.2.1 The Company prohibits discrimination, harassment and victimisation on the grounds of race, colour, nationality, ethnic origin, religion or belief, sex, sexual orientation, gender identity, age, marital status, pregnancy or disability.

6.2.2 Harassment is unwanted conduct that has the purpose or effect of violating a person's dignity or creating an intimidating, hostile, degrading, humiliating or offensive environment. Whether conduct amounts to harassment is judged primarily by its effect on the recipient, not by the intent of the person responsible.

6.2.3 Complaints may be raised with any line manager, any member of HR, or anonymously through the independently operated Speak Up line. All complaints are investigated; retaliation against a complainant or witness is itself gross misconduct.

6.3 Conflicts of Interest

- Employees must declare any personal, financial or family interest that could conflict with their duties, using the Conflict of Interest Register, within fourteen (14) days of the interest arising.
- Secondary employment or directorships require prior written approval from the Head of Department. Approval will normally be refused where the second role is with a competitor, client or supplier.
- Employees may not participate in a hiring, procurement or performance decision involving a relative or a person with whom they have a close personal relationship.
- Close personal relationships between an employee and their direct or indirect reportee must be disclosed to HR so that reporting lines can be adjusted.

6.4 Gifts and Hospitality

Value of Gift or Hospitality	Action Required
Under 50	May be accepted; no declaration required.
50 to 250	May be accepted; must be declared in the Gifts Register within 7 days.
Above 250	Must be declined, or accepted on behalf of the Company and surrendered to HR for charitable disposal. Re
Cash or cash equivalent	Must always be declined regardless of value, and reported to Compliance immediately.

6.4.1 No gift or hospitality of any value may be offered or accepted during a live tender, negotiation or contract renewal with the party concerned.

6.4.2 Facilitation payments — small payments to secure or expedite routine government action — are prohibited without exception, even where they are customary in a local market.

6.5 Confidentiality and Intellectual Property

6.5.1 Confidential Information may be used only for the purposes of employment and must not be disclosed to any third party without authorisation. This obligation continues indefinitely after employment ends.

6.5.2 All intellectual property created by an employee in the course of employment, or using Company resources, vests in the Company. Employees must promptly disclose inventions and execute documents necessary to perfect the Company's title.

6.5.3 Contributions to open-source projects related to the Company's field of business require prior approval from Engineering Leadership and Group Legal.

6.6 Public Statements and Social Media

Only the Corporate Communications team and individuals it designates may speak to media or make public statements on behalf of the Company. Employees expressing personal views on social media in a context where their employment is identifiable should make clear that views are their own, and must not disclose Confidential Information, disparage clients or colleagues, or post content that would breach Section 6.2.

Section 7 — Performance Management, Promotion and Compensation

Policy ID: MTG-HR-006 | Owner: Head of Talent | Last reviewed: 07 January 2025

7.1 Performance Cycle

Stage	Timing	Responsible
Goal setting	January (or within 30 days of joining)	Employee and line manager
Mid-year review	July	Line manager
Continuous check-ins	Monthly, minimum	Line manager
Self-assessment	First two weeks of December	Employee
Year-end review and rating	December to mid-January	Line manager and calibration panel
Rating communication	By 31 January	Line manager

7.2 Rating Scale

Rating	Definition	Merit Increase Guide	Bonus Multiplier
5 - Outstanding	Consistently exceeds all objectives and role expectations.	5% - 8%	1.50x
4 - Exceeds	Exceeds most objectives; a clear strength in the year.	4% - 6%	1.20x
3 - Meets	Delivers all objectives to the expected standard.	2.5% - 4%	1.00x
2 - Partially Meets	Delivers some objectives; specific gaps identified.	0% - 2%	0.50x
1 - Below	Does not meet the requirements of the role.	0%	0.00x

7.2.1 The Company does not operate a forced distribution. Calibration panels exist to ensure consistency of standard across teams, not to fit ratings to a quota.

7.2.2 An employee rated 2 or below is placed on a Performance Improvement Plan of sixty (60) to ninety (90) days with documented objectives and fortnightly reviews. Employees on an active PIP are not eligible for promotion or internal transfer.

7.3 Promotion

- Promotion cycles run twice yearly, effective 1 April and 1 October. Nomination deadlines are 15 February and 15 August respectively.
- Candidates normally require a minimum of eighteen (18) months in their current grade and a rating of 3 or above in the most recent cycle.
- Promotion to G6 and above requires a written case reviewed by a cross-functional panel of at least three members, none of whom may be the candidate's direct manager.
- Promotion carries a minimum salary uplift of 8% or movement to the grade minimum, whichever is greater.

7.4 Bonus

7.4.1 The annual discretionary bonus is calculated as: target bonus percentage (by grade) x individual rating multiplier x Company performance factor. The Company performance factor is set by the Board and ranged between 0.70 and 1.30 over the last five cycles.

Grade Band	Target Bonus (% of annual base salary)
G1 - G3	5%
G4 - G5	10%
G6 - G7	20%
G8 - G9	35%

7.4.2 Bonus is paid in March. Employees must be employed and not serving notice on the payment date to be eligible. Employees who joined after 30 September of the performance year receive a pro-rated bonus.

Section 8 — Learning, Development and Tuition Support

Policy ID: MTG-HR-014 | Owner: Head of Talent | Last reviewed: 07 January 2025

8.1 Learning Entitlement

8.1.1 Every employee is entitled to a minimum of forty (40) hours of structured learning per calendar year. Learning hours are recorded in the Learning Management System and are reviewed as part of the mid-year check-in.

8.1.2 Each employee has an annual development budget determined by grade:

Grade Band	Annual Development Budget	Approval Required
G1 - G3	1,200	Line manager
G4 - G5	2,000	Line manager
G6 - G7	3,500	Head of Department
G8 - G9	5,000	Divisional Director

8.1.3 Budgets are not transferable between employees and do not roll over to the following year. Unused budget lapses on 31 December.

8.2 Professional Certification

8.2.1 The Company funds one attempt at an approved certification examination in full. A second attempt is funded at 50%. Third and subsequent attempts are at the employee's cost.

8.2.2 Annual membership fees for one professional body relevant to the employee's role are reimbursed in full, up to 800 per year.

8.3 Tuition Reimbursement for Degree Programmes

8.3.1 Employees with at least two (2) years of continuous service may apply for tuition support for a part-time degree relevant to the Company's business. Support is capped at 12,000 per academic year and 36,000 in total.

8.3.2 Reimbursement is conditional on achieving a passing grade and is paid in arrears at the end of each academic term on production of an official transcript.

8.3.3 A repayment obligation applies if the employee resigns or is dismissed for cause within twenty-four (24) months of the final reimbursement:

Time Between Final Reimbursement and Exit	Percentage Repayable
0 - 6 months	100%
7 - 12 months	75%
13 - 18 months	50%
19 - 24 months	25%
Over 24 months	Nil

8.4 Conference Attendance

Attendance at external conferences requires a written case setting out the expected benefit and the knowledge-sharing commitment. Attendees are required to deliver an internal readout session within twenty-one (21) days of returning. Travel and accommodation follow Section 4.

Section 9 — Grievance and Whistleblowing

Policy ID: MTG-HR-021 | Owner: Group Head of Human Resources | Last reviewed: 07 January 2025

9.1 Informal Resolution

Employees are encouraged, where they feel able, to raise concerns directly with the person involved or with their line manager. Many concerns are resolved quickly at this stage. Informal resolution is not a mandatory precondition to a formal grievance.

9.2 Formal Grievance Procedure

Stage	Action	Target Timescale
1. Submission	Employee submits a written grievance to HR setting out the facts and the outcome sought.	5 working days
2. Acknowledgement	HR acknowledges receipt and appoints an impartial investigator.	5 working days
3. Grievance meeting	Employee is invited to a meeting and may be accompanied by a colleague or representative.	10 working days
4. Investigation	Evidence gathered, witnesses interviewed, findings documented.	20 working days
5. Outcome	Written outcome issued with reasons and any remedial actions.	5 working days after investigation
6. Appeal	Employee may appeal in writing; heard by a manager not previously involved.	10 working days from outcome

9.2.1 Where the grievance concerns the employee's own line manager, it must be submitted directly to HR, who will appoint an alternative hearing manager.

9.3 Whistleblowing (Speak Up)

9.3.1 Employees who reasonably believe that misconduct has occurred — including fraud, bribery, breach of law, danger to health and safety, environmental damage or deliberate concealment of any of these — should report it through the Speak Up channel operated by an independent third party, available 24 hours a day and accepting anonymous reports.

9.3.2 Reports are triaged by the Group Compliance Officer within five (5) working days. Where a report concerns a member of the Executive Management Committee, it is escalated directly to the Chair of the Audit Committee.

9.3.3 No employee will suffer detriment for raising a concern in good faith, even if the concern later proves to be mistaken. Knowingly making a false report is a disciplinary matter.

Section 10 — Disciplinary Procedure

Policy ID: MTG-HR-022 | Owner: Group Head of Human Resources | Last reviewed: 07 January 2025

10.1 Sanctions

Sanction	Typical Trigger	Duration on Record
Informal counselling	First minor lapse (e.g. isolated lateness).	Not recorded
Verbal warning	Repeated minor misconduct after counselling.	6 months
First written warning	Misconduct, or continued issues after a verbal warning.	12 months
Final written warning	Serious misconduct, or repeat within an active warning period.	18 months
Dismissal	Gross misconduct, or repeat within an active final warning period.	Repealable

10.1.1 The Company may start at any stage where the seriousness of the conduct warrants it. Progression through every stage is not required.

10.2 Gross Misconduct

Examples of gross misconduct, which may result in summary dismissal without notice, include: theft or fraud; falsification of records, timesheets or expense claims; deliberate disclosure of Confidential or Restricted information; harassment, bullying or violence; being under the influence of alcohol or unlawful drugs at work; deliberate circumvention of security controls; acceptance of a bribe; concealment of a security or compliance incident; and serious breach of health and safety rules endangering others.

10.3 Suspension

An employee may be suspended on full pay while an investigation is conducted. Suspension is a neutral act and is not a disciplinary sanction or an indication of guilt. Suspension will be reviewed at least every fourteen (14) calendar days.

Section 11 — Resignation, Notice and Exit

Policy ID: MTG-HR-030 | Owner: Head of HR Operations | Last reviewed: 07 January 2025

11.1 Notice Periods

Grade Band	Notice by Employee	Notice by Company
Probationary (any grade)	14 calendar days	14 calendar days
G1 - G3	30 calendar days	30 calendar days
G4 - G5	60 calendar days	60 calendar days
G6 - G7	90 calendar days	90 calendar days
G8 - G9	180 calendar days	180 calendar days

11.1.1 The Company may elect to pay salary in lieu of notice. The employee may not elect to shorten notice without the Company's written agreement.

11.1.2 Annual leave may be taken during the notice period only with the written agreement of the Head of Department. The Company may require an employee to take accrued leave during notice.

11.2 Exit Obligations

- All Company property — laptop, mobile device, access card, credit card, keys and documents — must be returned no later than the final working day. Unreturned assets are valued and deducted from the final settlement.
- Handover documentation must be completed and accepted by the line manager at least five (5) working days before the final working day.
- An exit interview is offered to every leaver. Participation is voluntary and responses are reported in aggregate only.
- Final settlement, including accrued leave and any end-of-service benefit, is paid within thirty (30) calendar days of the final working day.

11.3 Post-Employment Obligations

Confidentiality obligations under Section 6.5 continue indefinitely. Non-solicitation of Company employees and clients applies for twelve (12) months following the last working day, to the extent permitted by applicable law and as set out in the individual employment contract.

Appendix A — Frequently Asked Questions

Can I carry forward more than ten days of annual leave?

No. Section 2.1.1 caps carry-forward at ten (10) working days, and carried days lapse on 31 March. Exceptions require Group HR approval and are granted only where leave was refused for documented operational reasons.

I work fully remotely from another country for three weeks. Do I need approval?

Yes. Under Section 3.2.2 any cross-border remote work beyond twenty (20) consecutive calendar days requires prior clearance from Group Tax and Group Legal, and approval by the Executive Management Committee. Approval is never granted retrospectively.

My expense claim is 45 days old. Will it be paid?

Possibly. Section 4.6.1 allows claims between 31 and 60 days with Head of Department approval and written justification. Beyond 60 days the claim is rejected.

Can I use a public AI chatbot to help debug production code?

No, if the code is from the core platform repository or contains Confidential information. Section 5.7.2 prohibits entering such material into public or consumer-tier AI services. Use a tool from the Approved AI Tooling Register instead.

A supplier sent me a gift basket worth about 180. What do I do?

You may accept it, but you must record it in the Gifts Register within seven days under Section 6.4. If you are currently in a tender or renewal negotiation with that supplier, you must decline it regardless of value.

I received a rating of 2. Am I going to be dismissed?

Not automatically. Section 7.2.2 provides for a Performance Improvement Plan of 60 to 90 days with documented objectives and fortnightly reviews. Dismissal is considered only if the plan does not result in sustained improvement.

I resigned nine months after my last tuition reimbursement. Do I repay?

Yes. Under the schedule in Section 8.3.3, an exit between 7 and 12 months after the final reimbursement triggers repayment of 75% of the amount reimbursed.

Who do I contact if I lose my laptop at an airport?

Report to the IT Service Desk within two (2) hours of discovery per Section 5.3.3, and to local police within twenty-four (24) hours if the device held Confidential or Restricted data. The 24-hour security hotline is extension 4040.

End of document. For questions about interpretation of any policy in this handbook, contact hr.policy@meridian-tech.example. This document is fictional sample content created for testing and demonstration purposes and does not constitute legal or HR advice.